

Practical Wisdom and the Good Life: Reading Aristotle's Function Argument

An original lesson plan inspired by **Aristotle (trans. W.D. Ross)**'s *The Nicomachean Ethics* (Project Gutenberg). Not affiliated with or endorsed by Project Gutenberg or Aristotle (trans. W.D. Ross). Explore the original course: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/8438>

GRADE LEVEL	DURATION	TOPICS
Grades 11-12 / Intro College	65 minutes	Ethics

“Aristotle argues that the good life for a human being consists in virtuous activity guided by practical wisdom, not just pleasure or honor — what does that actually look like in practice, and is he right that all human activity aims at some final good?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain Aristotle's argument that all human activities aim at some good, and that eudaimonia is the final good at which all others aim.
- Distinguish practical wisdom (phronesis) from mere knowledge of moral rules, using Aristotle's own examples.
- Apply Aristotle's function argument to evaluate a modern conception of a 'successful life.'

Materials Needed

- Whiteboard
- Excerpt handout: Book I (the function argument) and Book II (habituation and the doctrine of the mean) in the Ross translation
- Case-study cards describing several different 'successful lives' (a wealthy executive, a devoted parent, a famous athlete, a monk)
- Graphic organizer mapping the function argument's premises to its conclusion

Lesson Procedure

Hook: What Do We Aim At?

8 min

Ask a student why they want good grades, then why that matters, then why that matters, chaining 'why' questions until reaching something wanted for its own sake. Use this to introduce Aristotle's opening observation that human action seems to form chains of means and ends pointing toward some final good.

Direct Instruction: The Function Argument

18 min

Present Aristotle's argument from Book I: everything with a function has a characteristic good tied to performing that function well (an eye's good is seeing well); to find the human good, ask what activity is distinctively human, which Aristotle identifies as reason; therefore the human good is activity of the soul expressing reason well, sustained over a complete life — eudaimonia.

Small-Group Case Analysis

18 min

In groups, students apply the function argument to the 'successful lives' cards, asking whether Aristotle would count each as truly flourishing. Groups must reference his qualifications: eudaimonia requires a complete life, virtuous activity (not merely possessing virtue), and a moderate supply of external goods like health and friends.

Whole-Class Discussion: Practical Wisdom

13 min

Introduce phronesis (practical wisdom) as distinct from technical skill or theoretical knowledge of ethical rules: the practically wise person perceives what the right thing to do is in a particular, concrete situation. Connect this to the doctrine of the mean and discuss why Aristotle thinks virtue cannot be reduced to a formula.

Closure

8 min

Return to the opening chain-of-'why' exercise and ask whether Aristotle is right that all these chains terminate in one single final good, or whether human aims might instead form several independent, irreducible goods.

Discussion Questions

- 1 Does Aristotle's function argument work — can we really infer what's good for humans from what's distinctive about humans (reason), the way we might infer a knife's goodness from its function of cutting?
- 2 Aristotle claims eudaimonia requires 'a complete life,' not just a happy moment or year — do you agree that a single tragic event could make an otherwise flourishing life ultimately not flourishing?
- 3 Is practical wisdom something that can be taught, or does it require lived experience that can't be shortcut by instruction?
- 4 Aristotle thought some external goods, like health, friends, and moderate wealth, are necessary for eudaimonia. Does this make his theory more realistic than views that locate the good life purely in virtue or purely in pleasure, or does it make happiness too dependent on luck?
- 5 How would Aristotle evaluate someone who has all the trappings of one of the 'successful lives' cards but privately lacks virtue?

Assessment

Students write a short essay applying Aristotle's function argument to a modern figure or fictional character of their choosing, arguing whether that person's life counts as eudaimonia by Aristotle's standard (virtuous activity of reason, over a complete life, with sufficient external goods) and identifying which of Aristotle's conditions is hardest for that life to satisfy.



Extension Activity

Have students keep a short 'practical wisdom' journal for a week, recording one situation each day where they had to judge the right thing to do in a specific context rather than simply apply a general rule, and reflect on what made that judgment difficult.

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